



energy for their groundstrokes.

Rick Macci, who coached superstars Serena and Venus Williams during their formative years, defines sliding as “a controlled mechanism to slow you down to establish better balance before hitting the ball.” No matter how athletic and agile you are, you need specific skills to slide correctly. “When you run laterally for a forehand, you slide with your right foot, and your left [back] foot serves as a rudder or braking action,” explains Macci. “The speed of the ball and the distance you have to cover dictate the timing of the slide. Like a baseball runner sliding into second or third base, if you misjudge the distance and start your slide too early, you’ll arrive late. Conversely, if you start your slide too late, you’ll arrive off balance, and that jarring ending will disrupt and ruin the timing of your shot.”

Strive for the early and optimal position of your body relative to the ball: Hitting the ball in the ‘strike zone’ with excellent balance allows

for timing the ball much easier. Dr. Mark Kovacs — a sports technology expert and physiologist who directed the Sport Science, Strength & Conditioning and Coaching Education departments for the USTA during 2008–11 — stresses footwork timing as a key to timing the oncoming ball. “When you’re timing the footwork, you’re trying to get your body in the right position and optimise your load parameters so you can release your energy most effectively,” Kovacs said.

“If you don’t time the rhythm aspect of what you’re doing correctly, then you’re going to be out of sync and you’re not going to load effectively. So, you definitely want to utilise the oncoming ball to set your feet, rotate your hips, load effectively, and then transfer your energy in the simplest, most efficient way possible.”

The ability to improvise is critical: “When some players are off balance or slightly out of the optimal position, they are so ‘cookie-cutter’ or

Fluid mechanics: According to coach Rick Macci: “An effective footwork remedy is to think of tennis as a dance, and you prance to get into a flow. Tennis movement on many shots is like a rhythmic dance. So stay light on your feet and coordinate your feet with the ball.”

inflexible that they cannot improvise to time the ball correctly,” notes Macci. “An effective footwork remedy is to think of tennis as a dance, and you prance to get into a flow. Tennis movement on many shots is like a rhythmic dance. So stay light on your feet and coordinate your feet with the ball. Arthur Ashe said foot-eye coordination is more important than hand-eye coordination in tennis. I recommend a rhythmical ‘drop hit’ drill. Take the ball, drop it, and, as it bounces up, hit it about hip height. Say ‘1-2, 1-2, dah, dah’ silently or out loud. This basic drill will reprogramme your muscle memory.”